

German Tank Destroyers

The earliest German tank destroyers used captured or obsolete light-tank hulls, with antitank guns affixed on top. Usually open-topped, they were issued to the Panzerjäger, or antitank artillery soldiers, to replace towed guns, thus improving their mobility. By contrast, Germany's Sturmgeschütz ("assault gun") vehicles were not originally optimized for destroying tanks. Rather, they were infantry support vehicles operated by the artillery and armed with low-velocity guns. Combat experience forced them to adapt, and they were soon upgraded with antitank guns.



▷ StuG III
Date 1940 Country Germany
Weight 26.8 tons (24.3 tonnes)
Engine Maybach HL120TRM gasoline, 300 hp
Main armament 7.5 cm StuK 40 L/48 gun

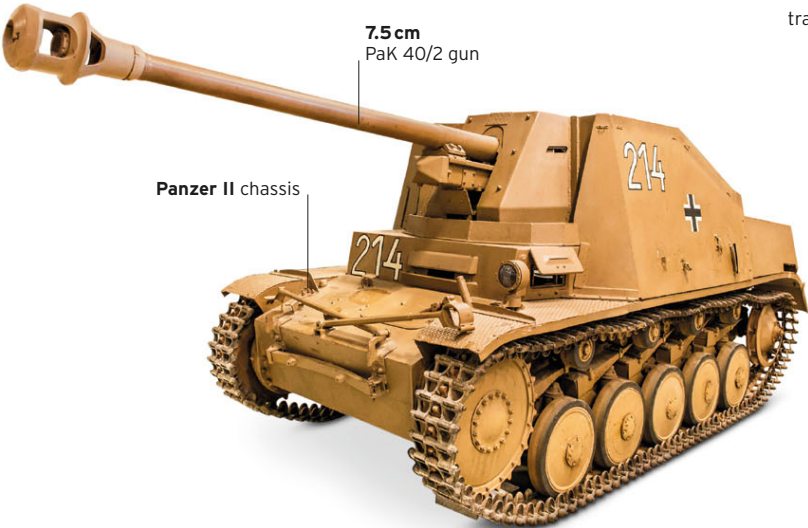
The first StuGs were armed with the same short-barreled 7.5 cm L/24 gun as early Panzer IVs. The StuG's low height and armor made it an ideal tank destroyer, and in 1942 the longer-barreled L/48 gun was attached to optimize it for that role. With over 11,000 built, it was Germany's most-produced armored vehicle.

◁ Panzerjäger I
Date 1940 Country Germany
Weight 7.2 tons (6.5 tonnes)
Engine Maybach NL38TR gasoline, 100 hp
Main armament 4.7 cm PaK(t) L/43.4 gun

The first German attempt to provide their forces with mobile antitank firepower, the Panzerjäger I matched captured Czech guns with Panzer I hulls. This was obsolete as a tank, but had much greater mobility than a towed gun. A total of 202 vehicles were built and used in France and North Africa.

▷ Marder I
Date 1942 Country Germany
Weight 9.3 tons (8.4 tonnes)
Engine DelaHaye 103TT gasoline, 70 hp
Main armament 7.5 cm PaK 40 L/46 gun

In 1941 German antitank guns proved to be ineffective against heavily armored Soviet tanks. The Marder vehicles were an urgent response to the German requirement to give greater mobility to their new PaK 40 towed gun by attaching it to tracked vehicles. Marder I used the chassis of the French Lorraine 37L supply tractor.



△ Marder II
Date 1942 Country Germany
Weight 12.1 tons (11 tonnes)
Engine Maybach HL62TRM gasoline, 140 hp
Main armament 7.5 cm PaK 40/2 L/48 gun

The Marder II used the chassis of the Panzer II, which was obsolete as a tank. A total of 650 vehicles were built and armed with the PaK 40 gun. Another 200, called the Sd Kfz 132, were armed with captured Soviet 76.2 mm F-22 field guns that had been converted to antitank guns by the Germans.

▷ Marder III
Date 1942 Country Germany
Weight 12 tons (10.9 tonnes)
Engine Praga EPA/2 gasoline, 140 hp
Main armament 7.62 cm PaK 36(r) L/51.5 gun

The Marder III series was based on the Czech Panzer 38(t) (see pp.66-67). This version used the converted Russian F-22 gun, like the Sd Kfz 132 Marder II. A total of 344 examples of this variant were built. Although they were mainly used in the Soviet Union, 66 were also sent to North Africa.

